

tablet or laptop, which analyses the information and initiates further activities based on it. Fuelband, for example, provides feedback on your exercise using the colour-changing LED indicators that gradually change colour from red to green. You can use the application to set goals or play games involving your physical movements.

Larklife uses intelligent algorithms to monitor your lifestyle and provides personalised suggestions for improvement. For example, if you have not slept enough overnight, it suggests that you have a protein-packed breakfast to compensate the energy levels.

While there are specialised health-related wearables available, off-the-shelf lifestyle monitors can be used to stay fit. In a detailed and inspiring blog post, Dan Hon writes about how he used a couple of common technologies including Nike's Fuelband to conquer Type 2 Diabetes.

Smart watches. Smart watches are being positioned as perfect companions for your smartphones. Pebble, MuteWatch 2.0, Fossil MetaWatch, I'm Watch and inPulse BlackBerry Watch are some interesting examples.

Pebble works with a smartphone to let users connect to the Internet and download customised watch-faces or applications that match their needs. Cyclists or runners can use Pebble as a bike computer, accessing GPS on the smartphone to display speed, distance and pace data. Golfers can use it as a rangefinder. Or, you can simply use it to control the music running on your phone.

Pebble's manufacturers are working with software companies to develop more and more applications for it. Plus, you can customise the watch.

"Want your watch to tell you when your next bus is leaving? Maybe you're jonesing to see your compile status or recent github commits. Think push notifications directly to your watch using the data connection on your phone. Want to check-in on your watch or create an app that can monitor your sleep? Pebble can send data from the

accelerometer and buttons back up to the Internet. It can receive simple alerts and notifications from 'if this then that' (ifttt.com) or our Web-facing RESTful endpoint. More adventurous developers can use the Pebble SDK, with its Arduino-like abstractions and simple 'C' structure, to gain full control of the watch. Multiple apps can run on Pebble, alongside watch-faces and regular notifications"—write the founders on their website.

Smart glasses. Augmented-reality glasses like Project Glass from Google



I'm Watch (Courtesy: www.imsmart.com)

and Vuzix' M100 Smart Glasses are the next most promising category of wearables. Of the lot, Vuzix seems to have had a head-start. The light headset has a small, widescreen, colour monitor in front of the user's right eye. The device has basic control buttons, and also Bluetooth connectivity to sync with smartphones.

The Smart Glasses is currently capable of streaming and recording video, but its scope goes beyond that. There will soon be applications that combine the location-awareness and video capabilities of the device. For example, if you are in a new city, and you want to know how to go somewhere, the device would be able to show the route merged with your real-time view and movements.

While demonstrating the product at CES 2013, one of the company's chief executives gave another interesting example—if you are in France, and you are looking at the menu in a res-

taurant, the glasses could translate the text into a language you understand.

Hearing tools. Earphones are perhaps one of the most ubiquitous examples of wearable technology. There are people who wear it for almost 12-14 hours a day, to listen to music and take calls. It is understandable then that earphones have become a point of innovation now. Comfort, safety, clarity, style—everything comes together in modern earphones. Earphones pack state-of-the-art speaker technology—with Philips, Bose and other renowned players in the game. Some earphones are styled by the world's most famous designers, and cost a tidy sum! Interestingly, the CES 2013 innovation awards list featured over 15 headphones, including those from Philips, Audio-Technica, Nokia, Logitech and iLuv.

Tracking tools. Wearable tracking tools are becoming popular in several countries, for keeping an eye on senior citizens, children and pets. One recent example is StickNFind—little circular stickers that you can stick on a pet or your kid's bag or shoe. It helps monitor the object's movement or set up a digital leash—you can set up a range within which the object can freely move, and if the child or pet wanders beyond that, you will get a signal on your mobile. These stickers contain a Bluetooth chip, temperature sensor and battery, and are designed to be used with a smartphone app, which shows a radar image covering a 61-metre radius.

Special needs. There are several wearable technologies for those with special needs. One of the oldest examples is the hearing aid, which has become quite advanced today in capabilities and form—thanks to MEMS technologies and advanced audio systems. Consider, for example, the LINX AUDIO Premium digital in-canal hearing aid, which is said to be the first in-canal hearing aid to combine advanced audio technologies with environment management tools for custom solutions to enhance comprehension in difficult